In fact, the Indonesians independently conducted their own maritime expeditions. From the third to the sixth century AD, they crossed the Indian Ocean in their outriggered ships and settled in Madagascar in large numbers. Thus, the first humans in Madagascar came from distant Indonesia rather than nearby Africa. The descendants of the Indonesian settlers still form a significant proportion of the population of the island country and the Malagasy language retains the strong influence of dialects from Borneo!

A CHAIN OF HISTORY

It is commonly argued by scholars that ancient Indians only wrote one formal history—Kalhana's *Rajatarangini* or River of Kings, a history of the kings of Kashmir written in the twelfth century. This is then put forward as proof that Indians did not have a sense of their history or of the continuity of their civilization. This is simply not accurate and it is important to recognize the degree to which this sense of continuity is deliberately maintained over generations. Even if one ignores works like Bana's *Harshcharita* as being royal eulogies, there are numerous examples, such as the Vanshavali tradition of Nepal or the Burunjis of Assam, where lengthy genealogical records were meticulously maintained. There is obviously a very developed sense of historical continuity.

Kashmir's Kalhana too saw himself as a link in a chain, and he tells us that he read the works of eleven earlier historians as well as inspected temple inscriptions and land records. He even criticizes fellow historian Suvrata for leaving out details and making his history too concise.[22] Most of these other works may have been lost but they all clearly existed. Moreover, Kalhana is followed by three other works that continue the chronicle down to the time of Mughal emperor Akbar. When Akbar conquered Kashmir in the sixteenth century, he was given a copy of Kalhana's *Rajatarangini* that was translated into Persian for his benefit. A summary was then included in the *Ain-i-Akbari*, the chronicles of Akbar's own rule, in order to link him back to the historical chain.